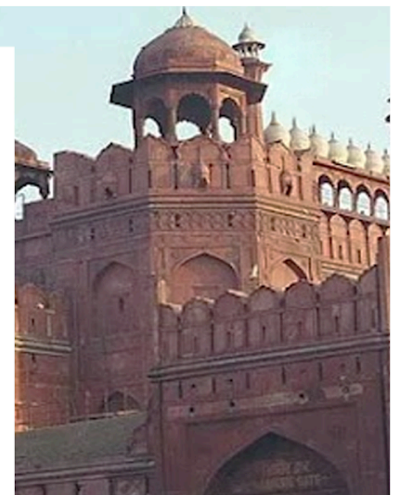
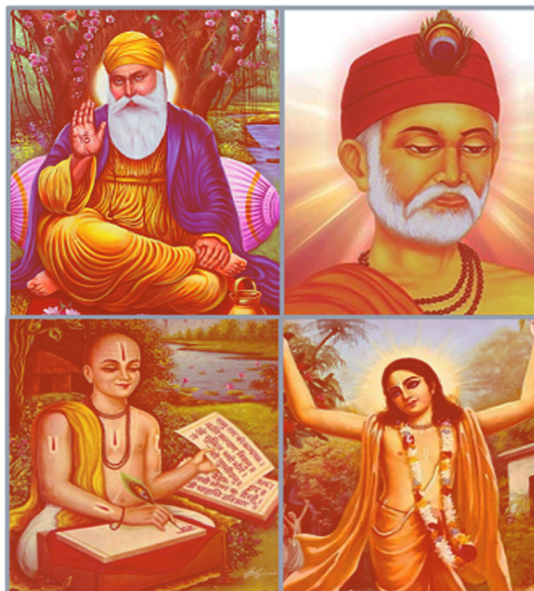
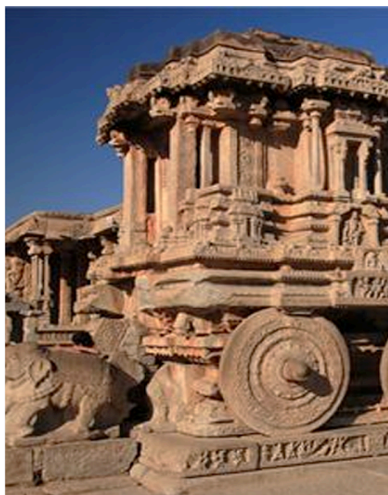


General Knowledge

Medieval History

STUDY NOTES

Bhakti Movement in South India



Bhakti Movement in South India



Bhakti Movement in South India

- The **Bhakti Movement in South India** emerged between the **7th and 12th centuries CE**.
- It emphasized **devotional surrender to a personal God** to attain salvation.
- The movement evolved as a **response to religious oppression** and promoted **equality**.
- It marked a **revival of Hinduism**, resisting the influence of **Jainism, Buddhism, and Religious orthodoxy**.

Factors for the Emergence of Bhakti in South India

- **Resistance to Jainism and Buddhism:** Bhakti saints challenged the privileged status of **Jains and Buddhists** at royal courts.
- **The power of Brahmins in worship:** Bhakti saints criticized Brahmanical orthodoxy, making **devotion accessible to all**, regardless of caste or gender.
- **Rise of Vaishyas and Shudras:** Artisans and lower castes, dissatisfied with their position in the social hierarchy, embraced the **egalitarian ideas** of Bhakti.
- **Simplicity of Language:** Saints used **regional languages** instead of Sanskrit to connect with the common people.

- **Integration of Settled Populations:** As tribal populations transformed into peasant communities, they became part of the emerging state systems and Bhakti communities.

Major Bhakti Traditions in South India

Aspect	Nayanars	Alvars
Tradition	Shaivism (Devotion to Shiva)	Vaishnavism (Devotion to Vishnu)
God	Shiva	Vishnu
Key Figures	- Karaikkal Ammaiyar - Appar (Tirunavukkaracar)	- Andal - Nammalvar - Periyalvar
Number of Saints	63 saints	12 saints, including Andal
Hymn Collection	Tevaram (Shaiva hymns)	Nalayira Divya Prabandham (4000 Tamil verses)
Philosophical Outlook	Worshipped Shiva as a warrior god who vanquished evil	Focused on devotional surrender to Vishnu
Major Themes	- Devotion to Shiva - Association with local sites and Kaveri Valley - Rejection of Vedic rituals and Brahmanical dominance	- Total surrender (prapatti) to Vishnu - Day-to-day imagery used in hymns (e.g., mother and child metaphors)
Female Participation	Karaikkal Ammaiyar , one of the earliest female saints	Andal , a prominent female saint
Criticism of the Other Sect	Nayanars criticized the Alvars for claiming Vishnu's supremacy	Alvars condemned the Nayanars for claiming Shiva's superiority

Social Impact	Promoted Shaiva traditions throughout Tamil Nadu and the Kaveri Valley	Helped spread Vaishnavism across South India
Caste and Gender Inclusion	Some Nayanar hymns, like those of Appar , challenged the caste system	Alvars included a woman (Andal) and openly criticized caste discrimination
Focus on Pilgrimage	Promoted pilgrimage to Shaiva temples and local sites associated with Shiva	Encouraged pilgrimage to Vishnu temples and holy sites
Legacy	Integral to Shaiva traditions in Tamil Nadu and associated with the Chola dynasty	Formed the foundation of Srivaishnavism and inspired later philosophers like Ramanujacharya

Themes in Alvar and Nayanar Hymns

- **Personal Devotion:** Focus on the **individual's relationship with God**.
- **Community Building:** Hymns addressed **devotees as a group** to create unity.
- **Critique of Rituals:** Saints opposed the **ritual monopoly of Brahmanas**.
- **Pilgrimage and Sacred Geography:** Hymns introduced the concept of **pilgrimage** by identifying specific **holy sites**.

Philosophers of the Bhakti Movement

Philosopher	Philosophy	Key Contributions
Adi Shankaracharya	Advaita Vedanta (Non-Dualism)	- Established four mathas (Badrinath, Puri, Dwarka, Sringeri). - Believed in the oneness of Brahman and that the world is an illusion (maya).
Ramanujacharya	Vishishtadvaita (Qualified Monism)	- Combined orthodox Brahmanism with popular Bhakti.

		- Opposed Shankara's mayavada and founded the Shrivaishnava sect .
Madhavacharya	Dvaita (Dualism)	- Asserted that Jiva (soul) and Brahman are distinct. - Opposed Shankaracharya's non-dualism. - Gave an alternate path of Bhakti for Sudras.

Major Philosophical Ideas

Philosopher	Key Idea
Advaita (Shankaracharya)	Brahman alone is real ; the world is Maya (illusion) .
Vishishtadvaita (Ramanuja)	Brahman and individual souls are distinct but connected.
Dvaita (Madhavacharya)	Jiva (soul) and Brahman are eternally distinct and can never merge.

Adi Shankaracharya

- **Adi Shankaracharya** (8th century CE) was a **philosopher and theologian** who revived **Vedic philosophy** through his doctrine of **Advaita Vedanta (non-dualism)**.
- He established **four Mathas** (monastic centres) to promote **religious unity** and spread **Vedic teachings**.

Four Mathas Established by Adi Shankaracharya

Matha	Location	Direction	Deity Worshipped	Associated Veda
Badrinath	Uttarakhand	North	Narayana	Atharva Veda
Jagannath Puri	Odisha	East	Jagannath (Vishnu)	Rig Veda

Dwarka	Gujarat	West	Krishna	Sama Veda
Sringeri	Karnataka	South	Sharada (Saraswati)	Yajur Veda

Philosophy of Advaita Vedanta (Non-Dualism)

- **Key Principle:** Atman (individual self) and Brahman (universal spirit) are one and the same.
- **The world is Maya:** The material world is an illusion. Only Brahman is real.

Stages of Truth	Explanation	Example
Paramarthika (Transcendental Truth)	Only Brahman is real, and everything else is an illusion.	The self (Atman) = Brahman .
Vyavaharika (Pragmatic Truth)	The material world, Jiva (soul), and God are real at a practical level.	Life experiences and relationships.
Prathibhasika (Apparent Truth)	Perception of the material world is false (like a mirage).	Mistaking a rope for a snake .

Core Teachings of Advaita Vedanta

Concept	Explanation
Brahman is True, the World is False	The only reality is Brahman; the world is an illusion (Maya) .
Atman = Brahman	There is no distinction between the individual self (Atman) and Brahman .
Self-Realization	Liberation is achieved by realizing the unity of Atman and Brahman .
Rejection of Duality	Opposed the idea that the soul and God are separate entities .

Key Contributions and Legacy

- **Unified Hinduism:** Through the **four Mathas**, Shankaracharya promoted **religious and philosophical unity**.
- **Revived Vedic Philosophy:** His teachings **strengthened Hinduism** against the rising influence of **Buddhism and Jainism**.
- **Inspiration for Later Thinkers:** Influenced **Ramanujacharya** and **Madhavacharya**, leading to the evolution of other schools of thought.
- **Simplified Spirituality:** Promoted the idea that **self-realization** and spiritual liberation could be achieved by realizing the unity of **Atman and Brahman**.

Ramanujacharya

- **Ramanujacharya** (1017–1137 CE) was a **theologian and philosopher** who provided **philosophical justification for Bhakti**.
- He **balanced orthodox Brahmanism** with the **Bhakti tradition**, making **spiritual practices accessible to all**, irrespective of caste or gender.
- He is the **founder of the Vishishtadvaita (Qualified Monism)** school of philosophy and **established the Shrivaisnava sect**.

Key Philosophical Contributions

Aspect	Details
Philosophy	Vishishtadvaita (Qualified Monism): While Brahman is one , individual souls (Jiva) are distinct but exist in harmony with Brahman .
Opposition to Shankara's Mayavada	Ramanuja rejected Shankaracharya's doctrine of Maya (illusion) and emphasized the reality of the material world and individual souls .
Bhakti as the Path to Liberation	Ramanuja promoted devotional surrender (Bhakti) to Vishnu as the supreme means to attain moksha (liberation).

Integration of Vedic Literature	Brought Vedic texts to the common people by composing commentaries in vernacular languages .
Environmental Philosophy	Advocated the protection of nature (water, air, soil, and trees) as sacred resources to be preserved.

Nine Scriptures (Navaratnas) by Ramanujacharya

Scripture	Description
Vedartha Sangraha	Reconciles different Vedic texts and presents the tenets of Vishishtadvaita philosophy.
Sri Bhashya	A detailed commentary on the Brahma Sutras (Ramanuja's magnum opus).
Gita Bhasya	A commentary on the Bhagavad Gita , emphasizing Bhakti as a path to liberation.
Vedanta Dipa	A brief commentary on the Vedanta Sutras .
Vedanta Sara	An introductory commentary for beginners on the Vedanta Sutras .
Saranagati Gadya	A prayer for complete surrender to the feet of Lord Srimannarayana .
Sriranga Gadya	A manual on self-surrender to Lord Vishnu .
Shri Vaikuntha Gadya	Describes Vaikuntha-loka (Vishnu's divine abode) and the state of liberated souls .
Nitya Grantha	A guide for daily worship and religious activities .

Madhvacharya

- **Madhvacharya** (1238–1317 CE) was a **Vaishnavite Bhakti philosopher** and the founder of the **Dvaita (Dualism) School** of philosophy.

- His philosophy served as a **reaction against the non-dualism (Advaita) of Adi Shankaracharya** and the **qualified monism (Vishishtadvaita) of Ramanujacharya**.
- He upheld that **Atma (individual soul) and Paramatma (Brahman)** are eternally distinct and **cannot merge**.

Core Philosophy: Dvaita (Dualism)

Aspect	Explanation
Key Principle	Atma and Paramatma are eternally distinct and will remain separate even after liberation.
Refutation of Advaita	Madhvacharya rejected Shankara's Mayavada (illusion) theory, arguing that the world is real and not an illusion.
Rejection of Vishishtadvaita	He disagreed with Ramanuja's concept of Brahman and individual souls forming a connected unity.
Pluralism	Emphasized Bheda (difference) , highlighting the distinct realities of soul (cit), matter (acit), and Brahman .
Bhakti and Liberation	Advocated devotional worship (Bhakti) as the primary path to salvation, particularly for lower castes .

Comparison of Dvaita with Advaita and Vishishtadvaita

Philosopher	Philosophy	Key Idea
Shankaracharya	Advaita (Non-Dualism)	Atman and Brahman are identical; the world is Maya (illusion).
Ramanujacharya	Vishishtadvaita (Qualified Monism)	Brahman and individual souls are distinct but connected.
Madhvacharya	Dvaita (Dualism)	Atman and Paramatma are eternally distinct and will never merge.

Teachings of Madhvacharya

Teaching	Explanation
World is Real	Madhvacharya rejected Shankara's concept of Maya , asserting that the world and experiences are real .
Soul and Brahman are Separate	In Dvaita Vedanta , the individual soul (Jiva) and Brahman are distinct and independent entities.
Bhakti as the Path to Salvation	Bhakti is the primary means for achieving liberation . He provided Sudras with an alternate path to worship.
Based on Bhagavad Purana	His philosophy was rooted in the Bhagavad Purana , emphasizing devotion to Vishnu .
Opposed Avidya and Illusion	Unlike Advaita, Madhvacharya argued that ignorance (Avidya) does not mean the world is unreal.

Philosophical System and Criticism

Philosophical Idea	Madhvacharya's Interpretation
Maya and Avidya	The world is real , not an illusion. Maya is not an inherent aspect of reality.
Difference (Bheda)	Emphasized the fivefold difference : 1. God and soul 2. God and matter 3. Soul and matter 4. Different souls 5. Different material objects
Criticism of Advaita	Accused Advaita of neglecting common experience and promoting an attributeless reality.
Disagreement with Ramanuja	Disagreed with Vishishtadvaita's idea that matter and souls form Brahman's body. Instead, he believed they are separate entities .

Impact of Madhvacharya on Bhakti Movement

- **Alternative Worship for Sudras:** Madhvacharya's **Dvaita philosophy** provided an **accessible path of worship** for **lower castes** through Bhakti.
- **Spread of Vaishnavism:** His teachings contributed to the spread of **Vaishnavism** across India.
- **Tours in North India:** Madhvacharya is believed to have travelled to **North India**, promoting the **Dvaita philosophy**.

Virashaivism and Lingayatism

- **Virashaivism** emerged from **Shaivism**, which focused on **Shiva worship**.
- **Lingayatism**, a distinct sect founded by **Basavanna**, emerged from Virashaivism in the **12th century** as a **reaction to Tamil Bhakti**.
- Aimed to address **social inequalities** like **gender discrimination** and **caste oppression**.

Origin of Lingayatism

- **Basavanna** developed **Virashaivism** into **Lingayatism** as distinct from Shaivism.
- The sect focused on worshipping the **Ishtalinga** (a symbolic form of **Shiva**) worn on the body.
- **Lingayats** believe in a **formless Shiva**, unlike traditional **Shaivism**.

Essential Features of Lingayatism

- **Social Equality:** Advocated for a **society without caste discrimination**.
- **Anti-Ritualism:** Rejected the **worship of multiple deities** and traditional rituals.
- **Shatsthala and Panchacharas:**
 - **Shatsthala:** Six stages to attain **spiritual enlightenment**.
 - **Panchacharas:** Five codes of conduct for followers.

Trinity of Lingayatism

Saint	Contribution
Basavanna	Founded Lingayatism; introduced Anubhava Mantapa , a platform for spiritual discussions.

Allama Prabhu	12th-century mystic and Vachana poet; emphasized unity of self and Shiva .
Akka Mahadevi	Female mystic; wrote Vachana poems and challenged social norms .

Difference Between Lingayats and Virashaivas

Aspect	Lingayats	Virashaivas
Origin	Founded by Basavanna in the 12th century .	Followers of panch peeth tradition, trace origins to Shiva.
Worship	Worship Shiva as formless .	Worship Shiva in human form .
Beliefs	Reject caste system based on Basava's Vachanas .	Do not fully reject caste in the Vedas.
Religious Practices	No temples or icon worship .	Temples and priests are integral.

Vachana Sahitya and the Sharana Movement

- **Vachana Sahitya:** A **rhythmic literary form** in Kannada, evolved as part of the **Sharana movement**.
- **Sharana Movement:** Focused on both **spiritual realization** and addressing **social issues**.
- **Vachana Poets:** Came from various professions, including **cobblers, tailors, boat rowers, and hunters**.
- **Madara Chennaiah:** Regarded as the **father of Vachana poetry**.

Nathpanthis, Siddhars, and Yogis

- **Nathpanthis, Siddhars, and Yogis** were **medieval religious movements** that criticized **rituals and social hierarchy**.
- Promoted **renunciation** and **personal spirituality** over institutionalized religion.

Beliefs of Nathpanthis, Siddhars, and Yogis

Group	Beliefs and Practices
Nathpanthis	Followers of Shaiva tradition . Founded by Matsyendranath , developed by Gorakhnath . Integrated Shaivism, Buddhism, and Yoga traditions.
Yogis	Believed in oneness with God through meditation . Promoted yogasanas, meditation, and breathing exercises .
Siddhars	Known for Siddha medicine . Focused on spiritual and medical achievements . Eighteen Siddhars contributed to Siddha medical knowledge .